

Daily Economic Briefing

Edition 2 | Friday 14 August 2026, 07:15 ICT

Window: Thu 13 Aug 00:00 ET → Thu 13 Aug 20:15 ET (Fri 14 Aug 07:15 ICT)

The 60-second read

1. **A record close bought with a soft PPI headline, not soft producer prices.** The S&P 500 rose 0.65% to 7,798.99, its first record since 7 August and the 27th of 2026^{[1][2]}. Headline final-demand PPI was unchanged on the month against a +0.2% consensus, and September hike odds fell to roughly a third^{[6][15][16]}. But final demand less foods, energy and trade services — the cleanest read on pipeline pressure — rose 0.4% m/m and 4.7% y/y^[6]. The tape traded the headline and ignored the core.
2. **Applied Materials beat, guided about 7% above the Street, and still fell about 5% after hours.** FQ3 revenue \$9.12bn (+25% y/y) and non-GAAP EPS \$3.50 both beat; FQ4 revenue guided to \$10.25bn against \$9.54bn consensus, with demand described as "unprecedented"^{[20][21]}. The stock fell anyway on weaker free cash flow as capital investment rose, into a name up roughly 190% over twelve months^{[19][22]}. For AI capex names the binding constraint is now positioning, not numbers.
3. **Memory economics cut both ways within the same session.** SanDisk closed +13.67% on investor-day growth targets, while Cisco fell 8.40% because those same rising memory costs pushed non-GAAP gross margin to 66.3% from 68.4%^{[19][23]}. Nasdaq +0.81% versus Dow +0.13% is that single input, split across two tape reactions.
4. **Both agencies cut 2026 oil demand on the same morning.** WTI settled −2.40% at \$81.25 and Brent −2.15% at \$87.07^[26], after the IEA deepened its 2026 demand decline to 1.6m b/d and OPEC cut growth for a fourth consecutive month^[36]. Crude pared a loss of more than 3.5% only on a Houthi drone strike on Aramco's Jazan refinery^{[26][35]}.
5. **The liquidity drain is now visible in the weekly data.** The Treasury General Account rebuilt \$56.6bn on the week while reserve balances fell \$49.3bn, and the domestic ON RRP facility sits at \$0.45bn^{[43][44]}. The buffer that absorbed previous drains is gone; further TGA rebuild now comes straight out of reserves.

1 Market recap

Index / measure	Close, Thu 13 Aug	Change	%
S&P 500	7,798.99	+50.49	+0.65%
Nasdaq Composite	26,803.03	+214.54	+0.81%
Dow Jones Industrial Average	53,839.99	+69.72	+0.13%
Russell 2000	3,052.85	+7.36	+0.24%
Cboe VIX	14.63	+0.08	+0.55%

Index levels are the AP close-of-session wire^[1]; Reuters' final wrap carries the same S&P level^[2]. An earlier Reuters print of 7,799.73 and a widely circulated 7,801.84 are respectively a preliminary settlement and an intraday quote — the session high was 7,816.70. The prior record close was 7,757.64, set Friday 7 August^[3].

Breadth supported the move: NYSE advancers led decliners by about 1.78-to-1 and the S&P 500 registered 28 new 52-week highs against a single new low^[4]. Real estate led on lower yields (+1.18%) with communication services close behind (+1.13%), and eight of eleven sectors advanced; energy lagged as crude fell^{[1][4][5]}. Those breadth and sector figures are mid-afternoon Reuters cuts — no dated closing sector table could be sourced (Annex A). The Dow is worth a second look: it was negative at midday and turned positive only into the close, with Cisco alone subtracting roughly 68 points^[23]. Any recap that stops before 14:00 ET reports a falling Dow.

2 Macro, policy and rates

July producer prices — a soft headline over a firm core

PPI, July 2026	m/m SA	y/y NSA	Consensus m/m
Final demand	0.0%	+4.7%	+0.2%
Less foods and energy	+0.2%	+4.2%	+0.3%
Less foods, energy and trade services	+0.4%	+4.7%	—
Final demand goods	−0.7%	+6.5%	—
Final demand services	+0.2%	+3.9%	—

Headline y/y decelerated from a revised 5.5% in June^{[6][7][8]}. The goods decline did the work; the ex-trade-services measure accelerated from +0.1% in June to +0.4% in July, which is the number to carry into the 26 August PCE print. BLS also revised March through June, so pre-revision comparisons will not tie.

Labour and rates

Initial jobless claims rose 9,000 to 209,000 for the week ended 8 August against a 202,000 consensus, with the prior week revised to 200,000; the four-week average was unchanged at 199,000. Continuing claims fell 22,000 to 1,777,000 and the insured unemployment rate held at 1.2%^[9]. A one-week overshoot against a flat four-week average is noise, not a turn.

Treasury's official par yields for 13 August had not posted at the cutoff and the Fed's H.15 still ends 12 August^{[10][45]}. Best-sourced market quotes put the 10-year at 4.65% (−5.4bp) and the 2-year at 4.16% (−5.2bp)^[11], though one desk recap has the 2-year down about 8bp to roughly 4.12%^[12]. Against the official 12 August close of 2y 4.20 / 10y 4.68 / 30y 5.24^[10], that is a modest front-end rally with the long end unchanged and 2s10s little changed near 48–50bp.

The Fed — a hike debate, not a cut debate

With the target range at 3.50–3.75%, two regional presidents spoke and split. Cleveland's Beth Hammack, one of the three July dissenters for a hike, said policy needs "some amount of restraint" and that the Fed "need[s] to act now" to return inflation to 2% faster^[13]. Richmond's Tom Barkin called it "an open question" whether a hike is needed at all, arguing tariff, oil and AI-driven demand effects may fade unaided^[14]. September hike pricing fell on the PPI: secondary citations put it between 32% and 40%, with a hold at 60–67%^{[15][16]}. The official CME FedWatch page blocks fetching, so treat that as a range rather than a level.

International and fiscal

UK Q2 GDP came in at +0.4% q/q and +1.1% y/y, both matching consensus, with June monthly output +0.3% after a flat May; services added 0.5% over the quarter^[17]. Bank Rate is 3.75% after a July hold in which three of nine MPC members voted to hike. Japanese corporate goods prices rose 7.2% y/y in July with yen-based import prices up 29.1%^[53] — a single-aggregator figure, flagged accordingly. No new US trade or fiscal action landed on 13 August; USTR posted nothing dated 12 or 13 August. One item worth carrying because edition 1 did not: the July Monthly Treasury Statement, released Wednesday 12 August at 14:00 ET, put the July deficit at \$432.2bn — a July record — with the FY2026 ten-month deficit at approximately \$1.8trn^[18].

3 Equities and earnings

Applied Materials — the beat that was not enough

Applied Materials, FQ3 2026 (reported after the close, 13 Aug)	Actual	Consensus
Revenue	\$9.12bn (+25% y/y, record)	\$8.99bn
Non-GAAP EPS	\$3.50 (+41% y/y)	\$3.40
Non-GAAP gross margin	50.4%	—
FQ4 revenue guidance	\$10.25bn ± \$0.50bn	\$9.54bn
FQ4 non-GAAP EPS guidance	\$4.02 ± \$0.20	\$3.69
Regular-session close / after hours approx. 20:00 ET	\$534.54 (−2.48%)	approx. −5%

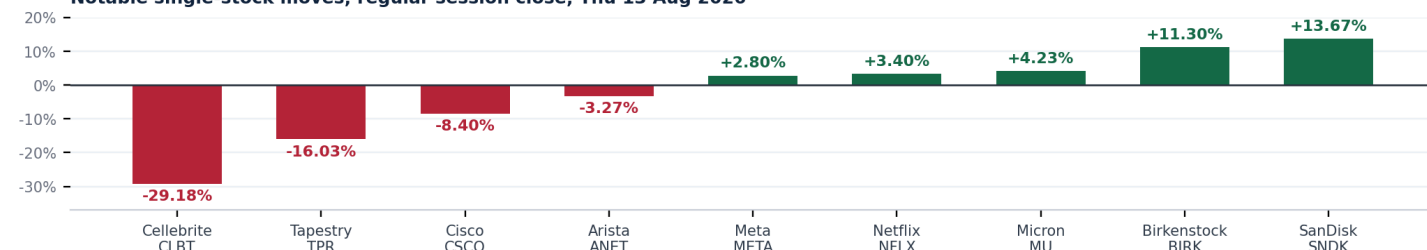
A clean beat, a guide roughly 7% above the Street at the midpoint, record operating cash flow of \$3.04bn, \$860m returned to shareholders, and 2026 semiconductor-equipment growth guided above 30%^{[20][21]}. The stock fell anyway. The wires led on free cash flow declining across the first nine months as capital investment stepped up^[22]. When a stock has doubled year-to-date, a guide that beats by 7% is the price of admission rather than a catalyst.

The rest of the tape

Cisco fell 8.40% in the regular session on the margin compression flagged in Wednesday's print — non-GAAP gross margin of 66.3% against 68.4% a year earlier, squeezed by AI memory component costs — even as five brokers raised price targets on the name^{[19][23]}^[25]. Arista fell 3.27% in sympathy. On the other side of the same trade, SanDisk closed +13.67% after setting mid-to-high-teens revenue growth targets through 2030 at its investor day, pulling Micron up 4.23%^[19].

Consumer names supplied the day's damage. Tapestry fell about 16% despite a modest FQ4 beat and a 16% dividend increase, because FY27 guidance of \$8.4–8.5bn revenue and \$7.80–7.90 EPS implies a sharp deceleration from FY26's +17% constant-currency revenue growth; Kate Spade sales declined year on year^[23]. Cellaire fell 29.18% to \$10.80 after missing and cutting FY26 revenue growth guidance to 15% under a new chief executive^{[19][23]}. StubHub fell roughly 20% as operating expense growth outran World Cup revenue, and Cerebras fell about 15% on a wide miss — revenue of \$180.1m (+74.3% y/y) against \$194m expected^[24]. Birkenstock rose 11.3% on a sales beat and a raised full-year growth guide despite a small EPS miss and roughly 70bp of tariff margin drag^[24]. Netflix rose 3.4% after Pershing Square disclosed a new stake^[19].

Notable single-stock moves, regular session close, Thu 13 Aug 2026



Regular-session closing changes. Sources: StockAnalysis.com quote pages^[19]; Birkenstock via TheStreet^[24]; Meta via Reuters^[4]. Intraday quotes for several of these names circulated 2–5 percentage points away from the close.

4 Commodities and FX

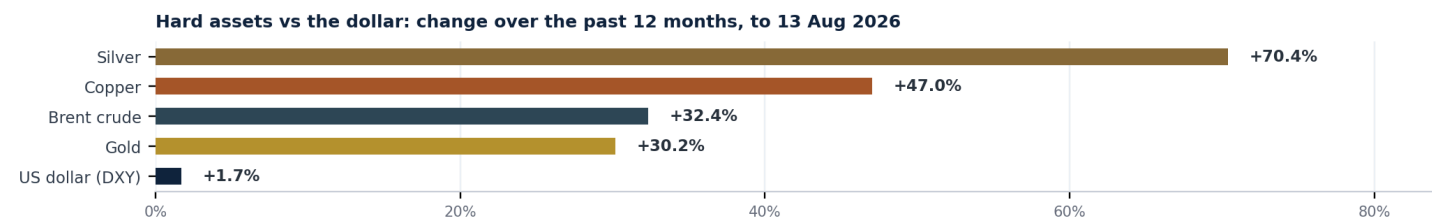
Asset	Level, Thu 13 Aug	Change	Source basis
WTI crude, front month	\$81.25/bbl	−2.40%	settlement ^[26]
Brent crude, front month	\$87.07/bbl	−2.15%	settlement ^[26]
Henry Hub natural gas	\$2.73/MMBtu	−2.69%	close ^[28]
Gold, spot	\$4,349.80/oz	−1.31%	close ^[29]
Silver, spot	\$64.29/oz	−1.40%	close ^[29]
Copper, Comex front month	\$6.5833/lb	−0.49%	settlement ^[30]
US dollar index (DXY)	99.96	−0.05%	close ^[54]

Crude fell on demand, not supply. The IEA's August report now sees 2026 demand falling 1.6m b/d, about 510k b/d steeper than July, and OPEC cut 2026 growth to roughly 580–600k b/d from about 780k b/d — a fourth consecutive downgrade^[36]. A US crude build of 17.4m barrels, the largest since 5 June, added to it^[26]. Both contracts were down more than 3.5% intraday before the Houthis claimed a two-drone strike on Aramco's 250,000 b/d Jazan refinery, the second on that facility in a week^[35]. On Hormuz, the US put transit near 9m b/d while Iran insisted the strait "remains blocked," with traffic near three-month lows^[37].

The EIA reported a +36 Bcf injection for the week ended 7 August against a +32 Bcf consensus, leaving working gas at 3,153 Bcf — 198 Bcf above the five-year average and 25 Bcf below a year ago^[27]. Gold snapped a four-day advance and remains roughly 22% below its January record of \$5,608.35^{[28][29]}. Copper's Comex record of \$6.7140/lb, set intraday on 12 August, was not challenged: the metal fell to a one-week low as Chinese buying softened, with the Yangshan premium down to \$96/t from \$115/t a month earlier^{[30][31]}. That sits awkwardly against London, where the cash-to-three-month backwardation reached \$207.50/t on 11 August, the widest of 2026^[31]. Physical tightness in London and fading Chinese demand are pulling in opposite directions.

Grains digested Wednesday's WASDE, which cut the corn yield to 180.7 bu/acre against a 182.4 trade expectation while putting soybean production at a record 4.519bn bu^[32]. Corn nonetheless fell 1.16% to 451.71c on profit-taking; soybeans added 0.19% to

1,167.00c with China buying 505,000t across three sessions; wheat was unchanged at 652.82c^{[28][33]}. In FX the dollar was essentially flat after touching a two-week high above 100 pre-PPI: EUR/USD 1.1528, USD/JPY 159.37 with intervention risk capping the pair below 160, GBP/USD 1.3478, USD/CNY 6.7452^{[28][34]}.



Twelve-month percentage changes as published by Trading Economics on 13 August 2026^[28]. Silver's move is independently corroborated at +70.2% y/y; the other four rest on a single provider's own trailing calculation. Year-ago endpoints could not be sourced directly (Annex A).

5 Derivatives, volatility and positioning

Cboe volatility term structure, 13 Aug	VIX9D	VIX (30d)	VIX3M	VIX6M
Level	11.37	14.63	18.68	20.93
Change on day	+0.28	+0.08	+0.15	+0.11

The curve is in steep contango, with nine-day implied at 11.37 against six-month at 20.93 — a VIX9D/VIX3M ratio near 0.61^{[38][39]}. Spot vol rose fractionally on a record close, a mild divergence but not a signal at these levels. Front-end vol this compressed prices near-perfect calm through the 21 August monthly expiry^[56] while term vol still carries the September FOMC. Cboe's daily statistics page shows a total put/call of 0.84, equity 0.61 and index 1.03, but the page carries no date stamp and the dated archive file could not be retrieved — the last confirmed dated set is 11 August at 0.81 / 0.63 / 0.90^[40]. Bond volatility could not be updated: the MOVE index has no 13 August print, and the most recent dated level is 72.09 on 12 August, down 7.5% on the CPI release^[51].

Positioning data is stale and about to be refreshed. The latest CFTC report carries positions as of 4 August, published 7 August — nine days old, and predating both the CPI and PPI prints. It shows leveraged funds net short 329,999 E-mini S&P 500 contracts and net short 78,333 Nasdaq-100 minis, with shorts added faster than longs in both; VIX futures non-commercials were net short 61,109 on rising open interest^[41]. Aggregator series put speculative gold at +197.6k net long and crude at +112.4k, trimmed^[57]. The next release lands Friday 14 August at 15:30 ET with Tuesday 11 August data — still a three-day lag, but the first read that includes the CPI reaction.

Credit is priced for nothing to go wrong. High-yield OAS was 272bp and investment-grade 79bp as of 11 August, both grinding sideways-to-tighter; FRED's lag ran two business days this week, so 12 and 13 August are not yet available^[42]. Supply is being absorbed without concession: \$80bn of investment-grade priced in the week of 4 August, the third-heaviest week of 2026, with year-to-date issuance at \$1.4trn, 9% ahead of the 2020 pace^[52]. Funding is calm at the front — EFRF pinned at 3.63% and SOFR at 3.62% — but the balance sheet tells the more interesting story. The H.4.1 released Thursday shows Fed assets at \$6.760trn (+\$11.4bn on the week), reserve balances down \$49.3bn to \$2.944trn, and the TGA up \$56.6bn to \$963.9bn, while the domestic ON RRP facility sits at \$0.45bn^{[43][44][45]}. Reserves are now the marginal absorber of Treasury cash-building because nothing else is left.

In single names, the options market priced a 7.5% move on Applied Materials into the print with three-month implied at 66.9% and a mild put lean; the actual after-hours move was smaller than that at roughly 5%^[46]. Super Micro traded 746,410 contracts in a roughly 4-to-1 call skew with three-month implied vol at 82.58%, concentrated in out-of-the-money August calls at \$40 to \$43^[46]. Dealer gamma positioning could not be sourced for the session (Annex A).

6 The day ahead — Friday 14 August 2026

Time ET	Release	Consensus	Prior
08:30	Retail sales, July, m/m	+0.1%	+0.2%
08:30	Retail sales ex-autos, m/m	+0.2%	−0.2%
08:30	Retail sales control group, m/m	+0.3%	+0.5%
10:00	U. Michigan sentiment, August preliminary	no named median	55.2
10:00	Business inventories, June	—	—
13:00	Baker Hughes rig count	—	—
15:30	CFTC Commitments of Traders (11 Aug data)	—	—
21:30 Thu	China CPI and PPI (09:30 Beijing, Fri)	—	—

Retail sales is the session. Consensus clusters at +0.1% headline, but published estimates ranged from −0.2% to +0.3% across calendars, largely because the control-group and ex-autos numbers get mis-mapped onto the headline; the +0.1% figure is the one carried by three named sources^{[47][48][49]}. The July final Michigan reading was 55.2, a five-month high, with one-year inflation expectations at 4.2%^[50]; no named August preliminary median could be found. Note for anyone reading other calendars: import and export prices and industrial production are scheduled for 18 August, not Friday, and the August Empire State survey falls on or after 17 August^[55]. Beyond Friday, Japan Q2 GDP lands Sunday 16 August (consensus +0.1% q/q), China activity data 17 August, and the FOMC minutes 19 August.

Annex A — what could not be verified

- **Official 13 August Treasury closing yields.** Neither the Treasury daily par yield curve nor the Fed's H.15 had posted 13 August at the cutoff; both were re-fetched. Market quotes in section 2 disagree by up to 4bp on the 2-year. FRED's DGS10 lags to 11 August.
- **Dated closing 11-sector GICS performance table.** S&P's own dashboards publish to month-end only, and every live sector page tried refused the fetch. Sector figures quoted are Reuters mid-afternoon cuts.
- **Closing market breadth, consolidated volume, and equal-weight versus cap-weight S&P.** Reuters' final wrap dropped the breadth block; only 12:04 and 14:35 ET cuts exist.
- **Dated Choe put/call ratios for 13 August.** The live daily-statistics page returns values but no date stamp; the dated archive file was blocked. Last confirmed dated set is 11 August.
- **MOVE index and VVIX for 13 August.** No 13 August MOVE print exists on any accessible source; VVIX is unavailable entirely (Choe dashboards render client-side; CNBC, TradingView and Google Finance all failed).
- **Dealer gamma / GEX and August opex positioning commentary.** No dated 13 August 2026 commentary found from SpotGamma, Nomura or bank desks.
- **Weekly high-yield issuance and HY/IG OAS for 12-13 August** (FRED lag running two business days). Investment-grade issuance is available only through 10 August.
- **US Dollar Index CFTC positioning.** DXY is an ICE contract and is absent from the CME financial futures file; no aggregator series exists.
- **Directly-quoted mid-August-2025 endpoints** for the hard-asset chart. The 12-month changes shown are each provider's own trailing calculation, not a computed ratio of two sourced prices.
- **LME official copper close for 13 August** (LME closing-price pages unfetchable); **CBOT contract months** for the grain closes; **front-month contract designations** for WTI and Brent.
- **A named institutional median** for continuing claims and for the August preliminary Michigan reading.
- **Whether other FOMC members spoke on 13 August.** One recap referenced "several"; only Hammack and Barkin were confirmed.
- **Japan, India and Korea data points in section 2** rest on a single aggregator and are attributed as such rather than presented as verified.

Annex B — sources

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Method note. Coverage window is Thursday 13 August 2026, 00:00 ET through 20:15 ET, picking up where edition 1 stopped; the previous edition's items are not repeated. Every figure carries a named source. Nothing is estimated, inferred or filled from memory: where a number could not be verified it appears in Annex A rather than in the body. Where sources disagreed, the more authoritative was used and the disagreement disclosed — four such conflicts were resolved for this edition: the S&P 500 close (AP and updated Reuters at 7,798.99, against a preliminary Reuters print of 7,799.73 and an intraday quote of 7,801.84); the July PPI core measures, which one aggregator transposed (BLS Table 1 governs); Micron's close (+4.23% from stated close and prior close, against intraday prints of 5.1-6.7%); and the July retail sales consensus (+0.1% headline, with the +0.3% and -0.2% figures traced to the control group and the prior ex-autos reading respectively). Two date-confusion traps were identified and discarded: a widely syndicated recap presenting the 12:04 ET Reuters snapshot — including a falling Dow — as Thursday's session summary, and two outlets republishing Wednesday's VIX close under a Thursday dateline. Charts are drawn only from figures cited in Annex B and do not duplicate any table. Tilt is market-wide; no portfolio or holdings commentary.